



In quake-hit remote Tangdhar Valley, CARE TODAY turns a rocky piece of mountain into a plush hostel for local schoolchildren

BEFORE



SYMBOL OF **HOPE**

Far away in the remote northwest, beyond the main Kashmir Valley, is Tangdhar in the Karnah tehsil of the Kupwara district—accessible by a single road link that traverses breathtaking snow-clad mountains, pristine rivulets, dense coniferous forests and a pass at an altitude of 10,500 ft. This rugged valley is surrounded on three sides by the Line of Control (LOC) and beyond that is Pakistan. Here, people and nature coexist with the Indian Army in a life that has become more secure with the ceasefire of 2003 and the subsequent quietening of guns on the border.

This security was shattered by the devastating October 2005 earthquake that claimed many lives and destroyed homes and infrastructure. One of the buildings that came down was a hostel that the army used to run under its Operation Sadbhavna, undertaken to win the 'hearts and minds' of people in the insurgency-wrecked Jammu and

Kashmir. Twenty children from poor families in remote villages close to the LOC, who were staying here and studying in the local Goodwill School, were rendered homeless. The hostel was closed for eight months, and the students were later shifted to tents and then to army barracks. As the rehabilitation of the quake-stricken areas picked up momentum, the army drew up a plan to build a single-storey hostel

NEW START: Army Chief General Kapoor inaugurates the hostel as Purie looks on



at a cost of Rs 43 lakh. CARE TODAY, which was already working in other affected areas such as Uri, approved a grant for this purpose in June 2006. The army authorities subsequently upgraded the plan so that the hostel could accommodate 44 students. They procured an additional grant of Rs 50 lakh from other sources.

Construction was challenging. The long and intense winter, coupled with heavy snowfall (in mid-April, there was still 5 ft of snow on the hostel ground), provided formidable barriers for logistics and building work. And yet, a rocky piece of land along a mountain has become the site of a palatial building called The Students' Hostel, Tangdhar. "No corners have been cut; no compromises have been made. We have ensured the best hostel building, not only in this district but in the whole of Kashmir Valley," said Khawar Jamsheed, the contractor who built the hostel.

The Chief of Army